

Paper Trail

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CW: Some Gore (Paper/People), Family Issues/Parental Abuse

A car drives through the Nevada desert, passing by tumbleweeds and faded road signs. Mark and Nancy are sleeping in the back, with Mark's head resting on his sister's shoulder. There they have been for the past five hours on the Burrs' yearly trip to California.

"Kids! You should be awake to see the sunset; it is gorgeous!" Carol, their mother, exclaims. The kids respond with a unified groan.

"You two should be awake for when we reach Paper Trail anyway." Mr. Burr interjects, his voice shutting down any whining coming from the kids.

Nevada's Top Tourist Destinations! laid on the dashboard, with a location labeled "Paper Trail" square in the middle of the map. "*A town of the future, with technology not yet seen in the 20th century!*" was the quote used countless times to soothe the kids' dismay after the closure of the dinosaur-themed putt-putt that they had been going to for as long as Mark could walk. "I'm sure it's going to blow that dinky golf place out of the water," their father reassures them.

"But does it have dinosaurs? It doesn't sound like it has dinosaurs," Nancy responds, followed by nods of agreement between the two children.

"Not every place we visit has to include dinosaurs, you two." Carol's attempt at reason falls on deaf ears.

While they argue, a paint-chipped sign passes by, "*Paper Trail: Population 2,*" and below that, just as faded, "*The proof is in the paper!*"

The town stood over the parked car, insignificant against the vast desert. Faded buildings with cracking skin screamed in the wind. "Well, me and your father are going to look over our directions again. Why don't you two go look around?" their mother says. "And make sure to keep Mark happy," she says specifically to Nancy before shooing them both away from the car.

They walked towards the center of the town, passing by the cartoonish facades of an old-western jail and saloon, which contrasted with the gallows situated directly in the center of the town, all of which were tied together by being completely made of paper.

"Future technology, my butt!" Nancy pats her brother on the shoulder. "This town just looks like a more rundown version of those cowboy shows we watch together."

"Yea..." he says, letting his head down. "Nancy, do you think our new mommy doesn't like us?"

"Oh..." Nancy is silent for a moment. A tumbleweed passes in front of them. "No, no, she doesn't, Mark; she just hasn't had much time to get to know you. Know us! I mean, it was only last year that Dad introduced us to her." Nancy nods her head, her face scrunching up. "She's the only mommy you have."

"That's not true though!" Mark's grip tightens, and they both stop in place. "You were there when that weird clown got too close to me at the fair and when those kids were gonna steal my

drawings.” He wraps his arms around Nancy and says, “You’ve been looking out for me like mommy would have! I know you will always protect me from scary stuff, forever and ever.”

Nancy wraps her arms around Mark. “I promise that I’ll always protect you, especially from the scary stuff. Forever and ever.”

As Nancy wiped the tears from her eyes, she spotted a building on the other side of the gallows. It bore the face of an older man, his gray hair depicted like rays of sunshine. “*Meet The Creator!*” read above the man’s face. The old man reminded them of Frankenstein, for Nancy, the scientist, and for Mark, the reanimated monster.

“Hey Mark, maybe we should go see the only person in town over there. Unless he died of old age,” Mark frowns, and she nervously chuckles, “or boredom.”

She leads Mark towards the building by hand. Mark does little to protest except to squeeze Nancy’s hand tighter.

They open the door, and a waft of warm air carries with it a stench of paper, glue, and something else they couldn’t parse. The walls are comprised of peeling wallpaper that only reveals more paper underneath, and the floor beneath their feet compresses with dry rot.

“Nancy, can we please go back, please?” Mark pleads as they step closer and closer to a door ajar at the end of the hallway. Nancy’s curiosity had to be satisfied. She pushes open the door to see the face of the man on the outside of the house in a cold grimace, his hands lightly clasping his guts as they stain the floor a deep red.

“Close your eyes, Mark. Close them!” she yells as she drags him towards the front door. Before they could leave, she bumps into a tall figure standing in the doorway. Looking up, they see a set of jumbled paper tubes hanging from a ripped dress. Only after seeing the figure’s painted eyes and blood-slicked hands reaching for them did they dash in the other direction, pursued by heavy footsteps.

The two kids scramble underneath the bed, watching the thing enter the room. Mark begins to open his mouth as tears begin to stream down his face before Nancy covers it. Thudding footsteps leave imprints on the floor as the creature limps only a few feet away from their faces. Its paper guts flop onto the floor, and the noise of them scraping against the ground reminds Nancy of the newspaper runs she does back home. Once the creature stomps over to the other side of the room, she books it from under the bed, heading towards the door. Her death grip on Mark’s arm causes him to yell, causing the thudding to follow right behind them.

Nancy burst out of the door running faster than she had ever run before, with Mark straddling her back as he held on for dear life. She spots the car to her right, next to an exit sign eroded by the elements. She tries to turn, but the thing grabs Mark’s shoulder. As Nancy turns around, the sound of ripping paper fills the air as starchy paste and blood are smeared on Mark’s back. One of the thing’s wet claws hits the ground with a plop as it cries out in muffled groans.

The two kids practically jump into the backseat of the car.

“Drive! Go! Go!” Nancy yells at her father, banging on his headrest.

“Please!” Mark begs, his face red and wet with tears.

Mr. Burr presses down on the gas, speeding out onto the dirt road. Through the rear window, the kids turn to see the tall thing stumble around a corner.

“Where in God’s green ear- “Carol touches the red paste mixture on Mark’s back and says, “Jesus Christ! How did this happen?” She shoots daggers at Mister Burr, “And why did you speed off just because your crybaby kids asked you to? What kind of man am I dating?” She turns to Nancy and says, “He is crying and covered in paint because you couldn’t keep him calm. I don’t even know why I’d let you take care of him. He needs his mother to protect him.”

She turns back around, leaving the car silent except for Mark’s quiet weeping.